

Chapter 38 Part 1

Zhao Ying very much appreciated Liang Shi's acting skills. After adding her on WeChat last time, she had also said: "I'll look for you if there's work in the future."

But at the time, Liang Shi had only taken it as a polite remark.

She didn't expect that just a few days later, Zhao Ying actually introduced her to work.

Liang Shi immediately replied: [I'm available.]

Zhao Ying said: "You don't even ask what script it is? What role? You just agreed like that?"

The background noise from her voice was very noisy, sounding like she was on set, and there was a hint of laughter in her tone, seemingly teasing.

Liang Shi originally typed a few words, but then felt that typing wasn't sincere enough, so she pressed the screen to send her a voice message: "Sister Ying, any script you act in must be a good script. What right do I, a newcomer, have to be picky? Besides, any work you introduce to me definitely won't be bad. It's more than good enough for me, I'm just afraid I won't be worthy of this production crew."

After hearing this, Zhao Ying was delighted. When she sent another voice message, the laughter in her words couldn't be hidden: "You really know how to talk, completely different from what Zhao Xuning said about you."

"But flattering me won't help. This time they're openly recruiting actors, I don't have the final say, you have to rely on your own abilities to get it. All I can provide you with is an audition spot. This Friday afternoon at 2:30, Qingcheng Theater fourth floor. I'll send you the audition scene in a bit."

Zhao Ying spoke with a bit of broadcasting intonation¹, lazy and languid, especially pleasant to listen to.

After she sent the file, she added: "I'm warning you in advance, Chen Liuying² is also auditioning for this drama. She wanted to audition for the second female lead but was rejected, so now she can only audition for the third female lead. If you're afraid of competing with her, you don't have to participate, I won't say anything. But..."

She didn't finish the rest of her words.

But Liang Shi, who had been in the entertainment industry for many years, naturally understood.

The rest of her words should have been—I won't introduce you to any more work.

There's a saying in the industry: Resources must be fought for, drama comes above personal feelings.

If you and a friend encounter the same script, the same role, you must still forge ahead and compete for it, each relying on their own abilities.

If you concede due to friendship between two people, that's insulting both the script and your friend, and directors won't use you in the future.

Directors aren't afraid of ambitious actors, they're afraid of those without ambition.

Conceding this and conceding that shows this actor has no persistence regarding their craft.

How could such an actor possibly act well?

Similarly, if you don't go because there's someone you dislike in the production crew.

Such actors also find it very difficult to get opportunities.

Liang Shi immediately replied: [Sister Ying, rest assured, I will cherish this opportunity and strive to get it. Clenched fist.jpg]

A double entendre.

Zhao Ying only replied with a cheering emoji.

Meanwhile, Zhao Xuning, who was about to get off work, received a message from Zhao Ying: [Tsk, Miss Liang San has quite high emotional intelligence.]

Zhao Xuning didn't reply at first. As she took off her white coat, she was still thinking, day after day, had she gotten into some kind of feud with Liang Shi?

Why was everyone talking to her about Liang Shi?

Zhao Ying: [You actually can't get along with Miss Liang San? Little sister, reflect on yourself.]

Zhao Xuning: [?]

Zhao Ying: [It must be your bad temper acting up.]

Zhao Xuning: [...]

A few seconds later, Zhao Xuning sent a death smile emoji.

Zhao Xuning: [That's because you haven't seen how awful she used to be.]

Chapter 38 Part 2

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With script study, the following days passed quickly.

Xu Qingzhu was also extremely busy with the new product launch, having no time to discuss that matter with Liang Shi, so the two tacitly glossed over the incident.

Thursday evening, Xu Qingzhu rarely got off work early.

Since Friday was the new product launch, everything was ready, and after Xu Qingzhu arranged and organized everything, she left work.

Her mind was now like a string drawn taut on an arrow, stretched tight, only needing to wait until tomorrow to shoot this arrow straight into the bullseye.

However, to be safe, after returning home she had another video conference with Sally and Cherry.

She curled up on the sofa while Liang Shi was cutting fruit in the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu asked Sally if she had done a final proofread of the PPT.

Sally rolled her eyes, "Blanche, I'm a designer, I'm not responsible for proofreading PPTs."

Xu Qingzhu: "...But didn't you get along well with Lulu who's in charge of this?"

Sally: "..."

Sally wailed, "Liang Shi! Come control your Blanche! I'm going crazy!"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She helplessly pressed her forehead, "Just confirm once more, just once."

Lin Luoxi said from the side, "I just confirmed with the media people too, they'll all arrive on time, don't worry."

Xu Qingzhu immediately said, "Cherry is so great. Sally, look at Cherry's efficiency—she could have finished the work in the time you spent complaining."

Sally put her hands together in a pose as if about to ascend to immortality, asking with particular sincerity, "Miss Blanche, don't you have a sex life?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Sally had always been abroad and spoke without restraint about such things.

"Please, I beg you to consider your Liang Shi's feelings, OK?" Sally said, "You're quickly becoming a workaholic! If this continues, your Liang Shi is going to be stolen by a mistress!"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Liang Shi just happened to come out carrying fruit and immediately explained, "I don't have one, Sally, don't wrongly accuse me."

She went around behind Xu Qingzhu and pressed her shoulders, but pressed so hard that Xu Qingzhu frowned and let out a muffled grunt, immediately reaching up to hold her hand.

"Does it hurt here?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded, "It's too painful."

"I'll massage it for you." Liang Shi softened her touch as she kneaded Xu Qingzhu's shoulders, saying quietly, "You office workers who sit for long periods are like this—not moving around often, your shoulders, neck, and back all suffer."

"You all?" Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow, "Aren't you the same?"

Liang Shi hesitated for two seconds, then nodded, "You're right."

Sally complained from the video call, "Liang Shi, your wife has really gone crazy lately. I never worked overtime abroad, but here I'm pulling all-nighters. I'm completely exhausted."

Liang Shi naturally sided with Xu Qingzhu, "Then just help her with it, it's a small matter."

Sally: "..."

She rolled her eyes, "Liang Shi, are you impotent?"

Liang Shi answered without thinking, "Yes, impotent."

Sally: "..."

She was momentarily speechless.

"If listening to my wife makes me impotent, then I'm definitely impotent," Liang Shi said. "Don't try to provoke me with that kind of talk—reverse psychology doesn't work on me."

Sally: "..."

There was nothing to say, just despair.

But Sally still helped confirm things, and afterward continued teasing Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu.

"Do you two really have no nightlife?" Sally said, "When night falls, you should do the things adults love to do, don't keep struggling with work."

Liang Shi: "...Isn't work enjoyable?"

Sally: "I think sleeping is more enjoyable."

Then she added, "If you two sleep together, it should be even more enjoyable."

Click.

Xu Qingzhu hung up the video call and closed the computer.

Sally's voice disappeared from the living room.

Xu Qingzhu said expressionlessly, "Don't listen to her nonsense."

Liang Shi chuckled, "It's fine, I'm used to it."

Sally had always been straightforward, and even when it was just the two of them, she would occasionally joke around.

But they were all harmless little jokes.

She could just brush them off casually.

Xu Qingzhu took her computer to the study, and Liang Shi occupied the living room space.

In a sense, their coordination was quite tacit.

Since she had an audition Friday afternoon, Liang Shi printed out the character biography and script excerpts for the audition role, and also asked Zhou Li for leave.

Zhou Li only asked her to wrap up her work in the morning and write a weekly report to submit.

None of it was complicated.

The living room was quiet now, perfect for Liang Shi to read the script.

This time it was a modern suspense drama, and the third female lead was a villain, but not an ordinary villain—she was a white lotus who turns black³.

She always appeared as a good person, but was actually the biggest boss in the drama.

White lotus turning black in modern dramas wasn't easy to portray, and such performances were generally criticized for poor acting.

Liang Shi found information about this production crew online.

The director was last year's Golden Mango Award winner for Best New Director and Best Director of the Year, and the leads were Zhao Ying and Shu Yi, who was currently at the height of her fame in the entertainment industry.

Chapter 38 Part 3

Liang Shi had seen this director's work before.

After watching it, she only felt shocked, so her initial feeling hadn't been wrong.

The director was definitely aiming for awards again this time, so they would certainly use suitable actors.

Liang Shi quite liked this aspect.

She liked this role even more.

In the early stages, she was a soft and weak white lotus⁴, occasionally playing the role of a caring big sister, but in the later stages she was a sinister villain. There wasn't a single hysterical crying scene—every scene involved tormenting the protagonist. Even when she was eventually counter-killed by the protagonist, she still maintained her dignity as a young lady.

The character was set as a pampered rich young lady, a princess and the pea⁵. After her family fell into ruin, she had wandered about and lived under someone else's roof. After turning black, she became a calm psychopath. When all her schemes were exposed, her attitude was simply—the winner takes all, do with me as you will.

—Regarding stepping onto this path of no return, I have never regretted it.

The story line was complete, the character arc was clear, and if performed well, it would be very impressive.

Most importantly for Liang Shi, this role was very challenging.

In the past, she had either played good people or pure villains. This kind of transformation from good to bad to indifferent was a first for her.

Liang Shi was full of anticipation for it.

When she read the script, she would occasionally speak the lines aloud, using proper broadcasting pronunciation. When she reached exciting parts, her voice would even suddenly rise.

Sometimes she would even startle herself.

Only afterward would she realize she had gotten into character.

This time was no exception.

When she read the line "This path was never my choice, but I accept my fate," her voice suddenly rose, startling Xu Qingzhu who was working.

Xu Qingzhu immediately closed her computer and ran out, only to discover that Liang Shi was holding a stack of papers, reading with vivid expression like she was reciting poetry.

At first she thought it was poetry, but after listening for a while, she realized it was a script.

She didn't interrupt, quietly standing at the doorway listening.

Liang Shi's voice was very pleasant, not just when singing.

When she read lines like this, it was even better. That voice was like turning on a television, with surround sound.

When reading lines, she was crisp and efficient, every word was clear—you didn't need subtitles to understand what she was saying.

After Liang Shi finished reading, Xu Qingzhu applauded.

This startled Liang Shi. "You... what are you doing?"

"You read that very well," Xu Qingzhu said. "Zhao Xuning said your acting was good, but I didn't believe it."

In the clip that had been leaked online before, there had only been a tiny bit of screen time.

It was indeed better than Chen Liuying.

But was it really much better?

Not really.

Moreover, being better than Chen Liuying's acting—did that count as good?

Not particularly.

So at the time, Xu Qingzhu had glanced at it but hadn't taken it seriously.

Plus, with what Bai Weiwei had said to her, she had been too upset to pay attention to Liang Shi's acting.

Only now did she truly feel that Liang Shi seemed very suited to being an actor.

Liang Shi: "..."

She belatedly realized, "So you heard everything?"

Xu Qingzhu chuckled lightly, "Unless someone's deaf, they would hear it."

Liang Shi: "..."

She had gotten into character and momentarily forgotten that Xu Qingzhu was still in the study. She awkwardly touched her earlobe, "Sorry, I disturbed you."

"It's fine, I followed Teacher Liang⁶ in cultivating some artistic sentiment," Xu Qingzhu said.

When she spoke, there was a hint of laughter in her voice, making Liang Shi's ears feel warm.

She always felt like she was being teased.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't think so. She had just finished her work, so she enthusiastically asked, "Teacher Liang, do you need me to help you run lines?"

Liang Shi cleared her throat softly, "Are you busy right now?"

Xu Qingzhu said, "I'm all done."

Liang Shi: "..."

She really wanted to get this role, so having someone run lines with her was naturally good. Even if her scene partner couldn't act, just having someone read lines would help her practice handling emergency situations.

It's just...

Xu Qingzhu...

She always felt somewhat awkward facing Xu Qingzhu.

"Come on, Teacher Liang," Xu Qingzhu said. "If you keep dawdling, it'll be time to sleep."

Liang Shi: "...Alright then."

Liang Shi's "alright then" sounded very reluctant, but Xu Qingzhu didn't mind.

She asked Liang Shi for a copy of the script, clarified what content she should say, and began helping Liang Shi run lines.

Liang Shi was initially unable to let go, but once she entered the scene, her expression and voice completely changed, no longer the gentle tone from before.

She seemed to become the character herself.

Even though Xu Qingzhu's reading had no particular inflection, she could still match the scene, and could even draw Xu Qingzhu into the drama.

For a moment, Xu Qingzhu felt like she herself was a character in the play.

Chapter 38 Part 4

When the last line was finished, Liang Shi closed her eyes and let out a gentle breath, finally coming out of character.

Xu Qingzhu had been watching her profile the entire time.

It seemed she had discovered yet another new skill of Liang Shi's.

The moment Liang Shi opened her eyes, she found Xu Qingzhu staring at her, and suddenly felt guilty. "What... what's wrong?"

"Teacher Liang, life really is full of surprises everywhere," Xu Qingzhu said with subtle meaning.

Liang Shi: "...Not bad."

She put the script away. "Thank you for helping me run lines. It's getting... getting late, you should go to bed early."

Her speech was still a bit stumbling, nearly biting her own tongue.

Xu Qingzhu was amused by her, but it was only for an instant. She immediately returned to her cool demeanor, those eyes looking at Liang Shi with a mysterious gaze, her voice rising slightly at the end with a hint of coquettishness in her clear, cold tone: "Teacher Liang, are you planning to enter the entertainment industry?"

Liang Shi suddenly sensed danger and answered with some wariness: "It's just acting in a play. Last time when I went with Sister Ran for an interview, I temporarily filled in, and Sister Ying thought I had quite a bit of talent, so this time she's letting me try. After all, I used to not know how to do any... anything, so now I'm just learning more. Don't you think so?"

She sat a bit farther from Xu Qingzhu.

"I think so," Xu Qingzhu said. "Teacher Liang, you're so polite now."

Calling people Sister Ran, Sister Ying—where was that arrogant, supremely conceited attitude of thinking she was the greatest in the world?

Liang Shi coughed lightly. "Well... you're quite polite now too."

Calling her Teacher Liang with every breath was making her panic.

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly, staring straight at her.

In the end, it was still Liang Shi who couldn't bear it. She said helplessly: "Just say what you want to ask, don't look at me with that kind of gaze. And stop calling me Teacher Liang."

She didn't deserve it, and couldn't handle it either.

"Hm?" Xu Qingzhu made a light sound, then scoffed softly. "Teacher Liang is so capable, what's wrong with me calling you that? After all, Teacher Liang now has a new skill every day."

The last three words were almost said through gritted teeth, which sounded to Liang Shi like—you're really good at lying.

Liang Shi sighed. "I just want to learn more things now."

"That's good," Xu Qingzhu suddenly moved closer to her, startling Liang Shi into backing away. The more she retreated, the closer Xu Qingzhu came, until she had cornered her. Only then did Xu Qingzhu speak in a voice like fragrant breath: "But Teacher Liang is truly gifted—you learn everything so quickly. When you have time, why don't you teach me too?"

Liang Shi: "...Well... I..."

She got stuck several times trying to speak.

Xu Qingzhu was so close that her breath disturbed Liang Shi's composure, leaving her mind completely blank, unable to think of how to explain.

Then Xu Qingzhu suddenly pulled down half of her sleeve, exposing her shoulder, and used a very alluring tone to whisper near her ear: "I wonder if Teacher Liang is still capable now?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Teacher Liang is so gifted," Xu Qingzhu's teeth gently bit her earlobe, almost pressing her entire body against her. "You must be very capable now."

Liang Shi: "..."

She swallowed. "I... I don't..."

Xu Qingzhu laughed softly, a laugh that made one's heart itch, made one's body tingle all over.

"Teacher Liang, you've been here so long, haven't you learned how to mark⁷ me yet?"

Liang Shi blurted out: "How could I possibly..."

Her words stopped abruptly halfway through.

"Possibly what?" Xu Qingzhu continued, still using that voice that made one lose all reason. "Not learn it?"

"I never forgot," Liang Shi immediately pushed her away, her ears red as if they would drip blood.

"I already told you I'm incapable of pheromone marking."

Liang Shi's voice was trembling, but she said in a broken-jar manner: "I can't do it."

Footnotes:

¹ Broadcasting intonation: A particular way of speaking used by radio and television broadcasters, characterized by clear articulation and standard pronunciation

² Chen Liuying: A character mentioned earlier in the story, appears to be an actress Liang Shi has encountered before

³ White lotus who turns black: A character archetype in Chinese fiction—someone who appears innocent and pure (white lotus) but reveals a dark, manipulative nature (turns black)

⁴ White lotus: A term for someone who appears pure and innocent on the surface

⁵ Princess and the pea: Reference to the fairy tale, indicating someone extremely pampered and sensitive

⁶ Teacher Liang: Xu Qingzhu is addressing Liang Shi with this formal/teasing title, acknowledging her acting skills

⁷ Mark: In ABO dynamics, a permanent bond created through biting during intimate moments, usually at the neck/scent glands